

QUEERNESS EXPERIENCES

TULUM GUIDEBOOK

A local, queer guide to the real Tulum: food, cenotes, beach clubs, nightlife, and everything nobody tells you before you arrive.

By Santi Solis (they/them) · queernessexperiences.com

● WELCOME

This is a list of my favorites, as a queer local. Every recommendation in here is somewhere I have personally been, eaten at, danced in, or trusted with my money and my body.

I'm Santi (they/them), queer, nonbinary, Mexican, and I've called Tulum home since 2017. I run Queerness Experiences, tours and group trips for queer and trans travelers. This guide is the free-flowing version of what I'd tell a friend the night before they land.

● MONEY & CURRENCY

Decline the conversion

Every ATM here (except BBVA) will ask if you want to "convert" your withdrawal to your home currency. Always decline: say no, or choose to be charged in pesos. It's a 5–15% markup dressed up as a favor. Let your own bank do the conversion instead. Same rule applies when paying at a restaurant: if the card machine asks, always choose to be charged in pesos, not your home currency.

There's no Uber

Tulum doesn't have Uber, which catches almost everyone off guard. Download **Eiby** before you land, it's the ride app locals actually use, and it'll get you fair prices instead of the tourist markup taxi charge.

● CENOTES

Cenote Escondido

Close to town, reachable by bike. You pay for entry at Cenote Cristal, then continue by bike, scooter, or whatever transportation you have across the road to reach Cenote Escondido itself.

● COFFEE

Story Horse

SPECIALTY COFFEE · TULUM CENTRO

A specialty coffee shop roasting its own beans, started by a Mexican-Irish couple (the name is the Irish way of saying hello, "what's the story, horse?"). Quietly one of the best cups in town. Baked goods, not a full breakfast menu.

Del Cielo

BREAKFAST · HEALTHY OPTIONS + MUNCHIES

"Del Cielo" means "from the sky," and the food lives up to it. Acai bowls, avocado toast, green juice, super yummy. Good whether you want something healthy or something more indulgent.

Bomba Snack

JUICE

Run by Fer, an awesome, super cool guy who makes genuinely great juice. A small spot, easy to miss, worth going out of your way for.

● WHERE TO EAT

All in town, except Arca and Hartwood, which are in the hotel zone.

Negro Huitlacoche

PRE-HISPANIC MEXICAN FOOD · VEGAN/VEGETARIAN/GF OPTIONS · JAM NIGHTS MONDAYS

My favorite restaurant in Tulum. Rooted in Mexican tradition with a creative twist. Order the corn. Monday nights are a local institution, with live jam sessions featuring the best musicians in town. Closed Tuesdays. Reservation recommended December–January.

Mestixa Tulum

MICHELIN BIB GOURMAND · VEGAN/VEGETARIAN OPTIONS · RESERVATION REQUIRED

I have friends who fly to Tulum specifically to eat here. The baos are extraordinary. Book ahead.

Veleta Market

MULTI-VENDOR MARKET · VEGAN/VEGETARIAN OPTIONS · EVENTS + PARTIES

Part food hall, part community hangout, part party venue. Don't leave without the pasta from Ciao Bella inside.

Burrito Amor

VEGAN/VEGETARIAN OPTIONS · A TULUM FIXTURE FOR 10+ YEARS

A reliable go-to in a town where most restaurants don't last two years. Good burritos.

● WHERE TO GET GROCERIES

For local and organic options, check out Chancelvita, Woolies Market, and Coco Amor. For a full grocery run, Comer and Chedraui are the reliable big supermarkets. If you're staying near La Veleta and need something in a pinch, there's also Super Aquí, though it's not one I'd go out of my way to recommend.

● BARS & NIGHTLIFE

La Guarida

BAR · COMMUNITY CENTER · RESTAURANT

Part café, part rooftop bar, part cultural center: a bohemian maze of rooms with live music, jam sessions, workshops, and movie nights, built around community rather than a tourist crowd. At night, different rooms often host different parties, each with its own theme. If you only go to one bar in Tulum, make it this one.

Negro Huitlacoche, Monday jam nights

Yes, it's on the food page too, but the Monday night jam session is a big enough deal to mention here again. Live music, local musicians, a real local institution.

Palma Central

SALSA TUESDAYS

Starts with a beginner-friendly salsa lesson, then a mix of DJ sets and live music. Non-negotiable, one of the best group nights out in town.

Cara Feliz

KARAOKE, MOST NIGHTS

Super fun: multiple microphones so more than one person can sing at once, and air conditioning, which matters more than you'd think.

La Pizzine

TWO LOCATIONS: LA VELETA + PUEBLO (TOWN)

Pizza with real live music venues. Both locations throw parties on different nights, check [@la_pizzinetulum](#) for what's on where.

There's no dedicated "gayborhood" here. Tulum's queer scene is woven into daily life rather than concentrated in one area. Red Room used to be Tulum's main gay bar, but as of summer 2026 it's closed (we'll update this if it reopens). For a broader queer-friendly night, La Guarida above is the real recommendation.

● THINGS I LOVE TO DO

Jiu-jitsu

Saturdays, run by a friend of mine, specifically for women and trans people. Open mat:

[instagram.com/openmat.mujeres](https://www.instagram.com/openmat.mujeres)

Atrevidas Dance Studio

Dance classes Mondays, Tuesdays, Thursdays, and Fridays. They also do striptease workshops, which can be arranged privately: [instagram.com/atrevidas.productora](https://www.instagram.com/atrevidas.productora)

Live Model Drawing Session with Clem

A one-on-one live model drawing session, run by Clem (she/her). Think of it like a boudoir shoot, but instead of photography, it's live model drawing. She also hosts monthly group meetups: [instagram.com/clemencedrouard](https://www.instagram.com/clemencedrouard)

Theatre in Spanish

Theatre classes in Spanish: [instagram.com/sedteatral](https://www.instagram.com/sedteatral)

● THE NATIONAL PARK (UPDATED AUG 2026)

Since the president visited in summer 2026, the rules changed in favor of visitors: entrance to the National Park is now **free**. A few caveats:

On foot or bike: free, through either the Tulum ruins entrance or the Cobá Road entrance.

By car or scooter: you need a reservation to drive/scoot in, and you have to go in through the Cobá Road entrance (not the Tulum ruins entrance). Use Ikal (one of our favorite local beach clubs, see the next page), fill out their form at ikaltulumhotel.com/access-registration and you're in, and they have their own parking lot. With this reservation, you're not limited to the park's posted hours, you can go in whenever you want, including early enough for sunrise or late enough for sunset.

No car or moto: go to either entrance, then take the little bus in for **20 pesos**.

Tulum ruins entrance fee: 265 pesos for non-local visitors.

● BEACH CLUBS

Most of Tulum's famous beach clubs charge mandatory minimums, valet fees, and tourist prices. These do not, or at least they're honest about what you're paying for.

Ikal, the local favorite

This is where Tulum locals actually go. The most reasonable prices on the coast, and the vibe is unmatched.

Arriving by car or moto now requires a reservation to enter the National Park (see the previous page), fill out Ikal's form at ikaltulumhotel.com/access-registration and you're set. Walking or biking in doesn't require a reservation.

Arena

POWERED BY IKAL (SAME TEAM) · OPEN WED–MON, 8AM–7PM

Same team as Ikal, just a smaller stretch of beach and a genuinely local-friendly crowd. Mediterranean food from Mera Spiaggia, sunbeds, cocktails, occasional music and community events. I haven't been myself, but friends who go regularly love it.

Dos Ceibas

NO MINIMUM · BEACH BEDS · QUEER-FRIENDLY CROWD · 2-FOR-1 DRINKS AFTER 5PM

The pizzas are delicious, 200–300 pesos. Get there early for a beach bed. Great energy.

Delek

NO MINIMUM · BIKE PARKING ONLY · RELAXED VIBE

Calm, quiet, fewer people. Easy on a bike, no car parking though. Good for a chill afternoon.

● GIVING BACK

Los Amigos de la Esquina (LADLE) is a local nonprofit offering art, wellbeing, and life-skills programs for Mayan and local Mexican kids. I'm on the committee myself, having started there as a volunteer and later become general manager, but LADLE is bigger than any one person involved. If you want to give back while you're here, this is where I'd point you.

WANT MORE THAN A GUIDEBOOK?

Come explore Tulum with me directly. Small-group tours to the cenotes, the food scene, and the town behind the town: queernessexperiences.com/tours

Have a question or want more recommendations? Email me: info@queernessexperiences.com

Thanks for reading. See you in Tulum.
Santi